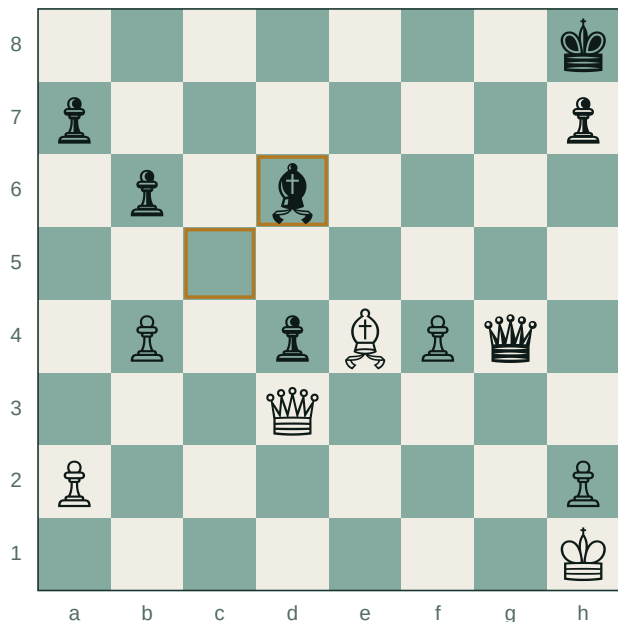


Active defensive resources: White, move 31

Active defensive resources

White to move



Previous move: 30...Bd6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

31. Qxd4+ Qg7 32. Qxd6 Qa1+ 33. Kg2

31.Qxd4+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. From d4 it attacks king on h8 and bishop on d6. Recorded reply: **31...Qg7**.

32.Qxd6 The queen captures the bishop on d6. Recorded reply: **32...Qa1+**.

33.Kg2 The king moves from h1 to g2.

At the end, nominal material is White 16 / Black 12 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +4: the balance goes from +0 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on h8. Geometrically undefended: bishop on d6 and queen on g4. Check for tactical protection.